

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, March 25, 2020, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:32p.m.

Mayor Lovett read the following statement: *This meeting is being conducted in accordance with the provisions of the Governor's Executive Order no. 2020-04 and the emergency meeting provisions of RSA 91-A to permit participation of board members by electronic means. Under the conditions of the current COVID-19 pandemic and the protocols established by the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), it is not reasonably practical for a quorum of this board's members to attend this meeting in person.*

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne (in Chambers)
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier (video)
At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser (in Chambers)
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren (video)
Mayor Charlene Lovett (in Chambers)
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau (video)
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski (in Chambers)
Ward II Councilor James Contois (video)
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone (in Chambers)

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

None

MAYOR'S NOTES

- As of March 26, Amtrak has temporarily suspended passenger service on the Vermonter until further notice.
- NH General Court has suspended all activities through April 10th. Until then, the State House is closed to Legislative members, Legislative staff and visitors.

Mr. Koloski thanked all who are checking on their neighbors. In the past couple of days, citizens have stepped in to deliver over 1,800 meals to senior citizens. He sent out a thank-you to them from all Councilors.

There was a discussion about how to thank people for their extra efforts during this pandemic and Council agreed to wait until a later time to continue the discussion.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

- **Fire Department** – The Fire Department has received \$1,600.00 from Mascoma Savings Bank to add to the smoke alarm program. We appreciate the continued support from Mascoma Savings Bank and other community partners for supporting this and other programs throughout the City.
- **Airport-** The Airport Terminal Building Project continues to move forward in spite of the current state of affairs, with a projected start date of Monday, March 23, 2020. The contractor has stated he is disassembling the 1927 Hangar. Its new home will be at the New Hampshire Aeronautical Museum in Londonderry, NH. The unknown is when it will be reassembled, as it will require meeting several hurdles, including current New Hampshire and local building code requirements.

Two FAA grants are forthcoming: The Environmental Assessment for the Runway Rehabilitation Project that is on the agenda for Wednesday March 25, 2020, and the Apron Reconstruction Phase I Grant, which will be on the April 8th agenda

Both, the Apron Project and the Runway Project are supplemental grants: \$3 million in funding for the runway and \$700,000 for the apron project. These projects will cost more than the supplemental funding, but will be part of other funding sources from both the FAA and NHDOT- Aeronautics.

- **CDBG-** On March 5, 2020, the Community Development Advisory Committee of the New Hampshire Community Development Finance Authority (CDFA) approved our CDBG application on behalf of the subrecipient, Sugar River Cooperative, Inc. to separate their water and sewer lines.
- **147 Main Street-** the NEPA is complete except for the Memorandum of Agreement between the Historic Preservation Office and the building owner.
- **Tax Deed Auction-** has been postponed to June 6th, 2 p.m., because of COVID-19
- **Earth Day-** Public Works is working to find hotspots for clean up
- **Thank you** – to City staff. He has asked a lot from them over the last week, and many of them have taken on dual roles as we try to not only respond to the COVID-19 pandemic, but also continue working in their normal capacity. All staff has stepped up and worked tremendously hard to protect the health and safety of the citizens and employees of the City.

The City of Claremont is also very lucky to have great partners. We have been working closely with the Federal Government, State of New Hampshire, Sullivan County, SAU 6,

regional health networks, Golden Cross Ambulance and many other agencies in and around Claremont.

Thanked the volunteer community for their help during this crisis, and the citizens who have adjusted to the changes we have had to make as a government and society. The initial support and respect have been great, but this will take some time to get through, and he is hopeful that the Citizens and Volunteer organizations in this community will rise to the challenge. As the Governor said “we are in the first miles of a marathon.” Now that the race has begun, we need to stick together to help us make it to the finish line.

Mr. Koloski said he is hoping information for the tax deed auction can be made easier to find.

Mayor Lovett noted a reverter clause has been placed in the paperwork for the tax-deeded properties.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Claremont Planning Board

A motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Mr. Stone to re-appoint Bruce Kolenda to seat 5 of the Claremont Planning Board.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Zoning Board of Adjustment

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Ms. Matteau to re-appoint Tracy Pope to seat 4 of the Zoning Board of Adjustment.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - no
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-1.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Matteau to re-appoint Abigail Kier to seat 5 of the Zoning Board of Adjustment.

Roll call vote:
O’Hearne - yes
Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - no
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-1.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Rebecca MacKenzie, Ward 2, talked about moving forward with a Claremont Climate Resilience Team. She said there is developing scientific evidence that there is a direct correlation to the COVID-19 pandemic and the climate crisis due to species interaction accelerated by loss of habitat and deforestation. She hopes the City will move forward with supporting this citizen-led Climate Resilience Team initiative.

Andrew O’Hearne, State Representative and Ward 1 resident, said the bill regarding the Claremont Police Commission passed the House and will now go to the Senate.

NEW BUSINESS

COVID-19 Update (Mayor Lovett and City Manager)

Mayor Lovett thanked the public for following CDC guidelines which are slowing the transmission of the COVID-19 virus. She thanked the City employees for all the work they are doing. Since the Governor declared a State of Emergency, she has been on calls to the White House, Senator Shaheen, Congresswoman Kuster. She said the County is standing by to assist as needed. On the Town Hall teleconference with Congresswoman Kuster something was brought up about the government trying hard to partner with the private sector to get resources to the medical community. It was announced at that meeting that NH had just received its second shipment from the federal stockpile of PPE (personal protective equipment). The State set up a website, [NHEconomy.com/ppehelp](https://NHEconomy.com/pphelp) for private organizations to donate PPE.

Mr. Morris said there are limited resources open in City Hall. Most offices are closed to walk-in traffic. All offices are taking phone calls and receiving emails. The front doors of City Hall are the only open doors. There is a Drop Box in front of Central Collections for people to drop off payments. Online, the credit card companies are still charging their credit card fees, but the \$1 transaction fee has been waived. The Assessing and City Manager's offices are open for walk-in traffic. All paperwork for all departments can be deposited in the Drop Box. He's been working with Valley Regional Hospital planning extra beds, if needed in the City. On Facebook Live, the Parks and Recreation Department is doing art and exercise classes. The City is organizing reading of childrens' books online. We are trying to keep up the community support. The Planning and Development Department is working hard with local businesses. The Human Resources office is working on unemployment issues.

Fire Chief Bryan Burr said he is participating in noontime teleconferences with the State Division of Safety, Fire Marshal's office and Emergency Management. The biggest question is where is the PPE. It is in short supply but, the City is managing it well. He assured the public that Fire, Police, Ambulance will be there to protect the citizens. Regarding the Med Surge, seven sites have been designated. Ours is DHMC. They can accept 1,200 patients. The latest update is that NH is the fourth most aggressive state in the country regarding the measures we are taking. He talked about the twice-a-day teleconference with staff and others throughout the City/County. He said Mr. Morris' leadership is a testament to the Fire Service (Mr. Morris was a firefighter in Idaho) and he said Derek Ferland's military background is a great benefit. The City is doing a good job because of the leadership shown.

Where people can donate any PPE that they have can be discussed at the 8 a.m. meeting and that information will be put on the website.

Mr. Morris thanked the local companies for stepping up to help out (i.e. Coltac is making surgical masks and gowns).

Resolution 2020-18 Accept and Expend One Time Monies from State of NH for Arrowhead Upgrades and Opera House HVAC – Public Hearing

WHEREAS, in October of 2019 the City of Claremont received unanticipated revenue in the amount of up to \$341,154 from the State of NH; and

WHEREAS, the City would like to use said funds for needed repairs for Arrowhead and the City Hall HVAC;

NOW THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED by the City Council to raise, appropriate and expend the sum of up to \$341,154, said sum to come from unanticipated revenue (with no impact on the tax rate) and;

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Council hereby authorizes the City Manager or his designees to undertake all actions and execute all documents as may be required to implement this resolution. *(2/3 vote required)*

Mr. Morris said the Arrowhead Windows and Doors Project; Arrowhead Furnace Project; and Arrowhead Roof Project are estimated to cost \$95,600. The Opera House HVAC bid is due back April 3rd, and it is expected to be about \$150,000 to \$165,000. At this time, the City is asking the Council to accept the money from the Governor and allow us to expend it on these projects. There is a 12-week turnaround for the HVAC units. The City will come back to Council to request to spend the rest of the funds on the sidewalk project next to the Police Department and the Farwell Block (ices over due to drainage problems), and the insulation & LED lighting project at the Planning and Development Department.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to adopt Resolution 2020-18 Accept and Expend One Time Monies from State of NH for Arrowhead Upgrades and Opera House HVAC.

Ms. Kier read the resolution into the record.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing. No one spoke. She closed it.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Resolution 2020-19 Accept and Expend FAA Environmental Assessment Grant for
Airport Runway Project – Public Hearing

WHEREAS the City is undertaking a runway improvement project at the Claremont Municipal Airport (the "Airport"); and

WHEREAS the City of Claremont, NH, has been approved for funding to conduct an environmental assessment for said runaway project in the amount of \$38,840 and;

WHEREAS the City would like to now accept and expend said funds;

NOW THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED to raise, appropriate and expend the sum of \$38,840 with \$34,956 (90%) to come from the FAA, \$1,942 (5%) to come from the NHDOT, and the remaining \$1,942 (5%) as our local match to be taken from the Airport Reserve Account (to have no impact on the tax rate); and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City Manager or his designees are hereby authorized to execute all documents and undertake all actions as may be required to implement this resolution. *(2/3 Vote Required)*

Chief Burr gave an overview of the request. \$3 million will go toward reconstruction of the Airport runway. This project won't have a shovel in the ground for a couple of years. One item that is needed is an environmental assessment because it is anticipated to disturb a considerable amount of turf. This is one of many requests that will come before the Council for this project. The City's share will come out of the Airport Reserve Account which comes from rents/leases and airport fuel.

A motion was made by Mr. Contois and seconded by Ms. Kier to adopt Resolution 2020-19 Accept and Expend FAA Environmental Assessment Grant for Airport Runway Project.

Mr. Contois read the resolution into the record

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing. No one spoke. She closed it.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Mayor Lovett said the next Council meeting on April 8th, may be a virtual meeting.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Ms. Sweetser said that right now evictions have stopped, and people have asked if, when the order is lifted, they can be evicted if they owe money. She has heard from multi-family property owners concerns about being able to pay their bills. She asked what the City can do to help.

Mr. O'Hearne would like the City's sign boards reflect information, other than computer websites, about COVID-19 as there are a lot of older people who don't have computers.

Mr. O'Hearne asked if the Police Department has reached out to the homeless people to make sure they are okay and that they are kept apprised of what is going on.

Mr. O'Hearne said it was brought to his attention by other board members who meet in Council Chambers that the City Code book that used to be in Council Chambers is not there anymore.

Mayor Lovett said she has it and if other people want it, they can coordinate their request through the Council Clerk. She said she utilizes it at home since there is no place to work here.

Mr. Contois thanked Chief Burr and his leadership for the work done on the Airport. He also thanked the City Manager for sending out lots of information to the Council on a daily basis; it keeps him well informed. He said he works at the Claremont Senior Center and has received two calls from City staff asking if their seniors need any help and he appreciates that.

Ms. Matteau echoed the thanks to Mr. Morris and Chief Burr for their leadership.

Mr. Contois and Ms. Matteau also said thank you to Mayor Lovett.

Mr. Koloski asked if a master list of social service agencies, with their services, (not just for COVID-19) could be made available.

Mr. Koloski said there is a state link for people who want to volunteer. Mayor Lovett said it is NH Responds.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 7:37 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. O'Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council